YIXING AUDIO GUIDE · PART III

Shanjuan Cave Scenic Area — English Audio Guide

Complete 8-Stop Spoken Tour Script · Neural Voice (AvaMultilingualNeural) with 2.5s Paragraph Pauses & Traditional Guzheng/Dizi SFX · Total Duration: 21m 51s

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STOP 01 · 1:38 · GUZHENG & DIZI INTRO · shanjuan_01_intro.mp3

Welcome & Overview: The Birthplace of Cave Tourism in China

Visitor Center, Commercial Street, Mr. Chu Nanqiang's 1934 Opening & The Three Great Wonder Caves of the World

Hello everyone! Welcome to the Shanjuan Cave Scenic Area—celebrated as the birthplace of karst cave tourism in China and the legendary setting of the classic Chinese romance, The Butterfly Lovers (Liang Shanbo and Zhu Yingtai). It is a real pleasure to be your guide today and share the stories and wonders of Shanjuan Cave with you.

Please follow me this way. Right outside the Visitor Center on our left is the commercial street, which features newly introduced travel photography studios, convenience stores, the Limo Mountain House restaurant, and a themed cultural and creative shop.

Located in Zhangzhu Town, about 23 kilometers southwest of downtown Yixing, the Shanjuan Cave Scenic Area is made up of five main themes: the karst caves, Butterfly Lovers culture, the Guoshan Stele, ancient and rare trees, and leisure attractions. Back in 1921, local visionary Mr. Chu Nanqiang began developing the cave. After thirteen years of tireless work, it officially opened to the public on November 11, 1934—pioneering cave tourism in China. Early on, it was hailed alongside the Caves of Han-sur-Lesse in Belgium and the caves of Lyon in France as one of the "Three Great Wonder Caves of the World." Surrounded by lush hills and clear waters, the cave's natural rock formations are so breathtaking that ancient scholars praised it as an "Ancient Sacred Marvel" and a "Fairy Capital in the Mortal World."

STOP 02 · 2:50 · GUZHENG GLISSANDO · shanjuan_02_pailou.mp3

The Grand Archway (Pailou) & The Ancient Names of Yixing

Juntao Glazed Roof Tiles, Fei Xinwo's Left-Handed Calligraphy & How Jingxi and Yangxian Became Yixing

Walking across the plaza, right in front of us stands the majestic Shanjuan Cave Archway. Look up at the bright yellow glazed tiles on the roof—they were crafted using Yixing's famous traditional Juntao glazed pottery technique. The three bold characters for "Shanjuan Cave" on the gate were written by the renowned left-handed calligrapher Mr. Fei Xinwo. On both sides of the pillars, you can see a couplet written in 1986 by Mr. Huang Yanghui, a famous painter and calligrapher from Wuxi who studied under Master Xu Beihong. It reads: "Every step in Jingxi is a scenic wonder; every corner of Yangxian holds a hidden grotto heaven."

Both Jingxi and Yangxian are ancient names for Yixing. Over 6,000 years ago, this area faced the sea with mountains covered in wild brambles—called jing—and streams flowing down into the valleys, giving rise to the name "Jingxi," or Bramble Stream. Later, in 221 BC, when the First Emperor Qin Shi Huang unified China and replaced the feudal system with 36 prefectures, Jingxi was renamed "Yangxian." During the Jin Dynasty, a local hero named Zhou Qi raised an army three times to help the imperial court put down rebellions. To honor his achievements, the court renamed the prefecture "Yixing," meaning Righteous

Prosperity. Later, during the Song Dynasty, to avoid using a character from Emperor Taizong's personal name, the first character was changed to the "Yi" we use today—meaning a place suitable for living and thriving. Finally, in 1988, Yixing became a county-level city.

With over 7,000 years of pottery-making history and more than 2,200 years as an established county, Yixing is proudly known across China as the "Ancient Capital of Pottery, Oasis of Tea, Ocean of Bamboo, and World of Caves." According to local historical records, there are 87 karst caves scattered across Yixing's southwestern mountains, five of which are now open to visitors. Among them, Shanjuan Cave is world-famous for having a cave inside a mountain, a river inside a cave, and boats gliding along that underground river.

STOP 03 · 2:30 · BREEZE & CHIME · shanjuan_03_statue_museum.mp3

Master Shanjuan Statue & Chu Nanqiang Exhibition Hall

The Sage Who Declined Emperor Shun's Throne, the Ancient "Lei" Plow & The Pioneer of Chinese Cave Tourism

Please follow me through the archway. On our left stands a statue of the venerable Master Shanjuan. Legend has it that he lived here as a hermit, which is how Shanjuan Cave got its name. Master Shanjuan was a wise sage and the teacher of the legendary Emperors Yao and Shun. According to ancient texts, when Emperor Shun grew old, he saw that Shanjuan had the wisdom and virtue to govern the land, and offered to pass the throne to him. However, Master Shanjuan replied: "I live freely and happily between heaven and earth—why would I ever need the throne?" To avoid Emperor Shun's repeated offers, he traveled all the way from Changde in Hunan Province to these mountains, found this karst cave, and lived here in seclusion. He also brought advanced farming techniques to the local people and did many good deeds. To remember him, locals named the cave where he lived "Shanjuan Cave."

Notice the tool he is holding in his hand—it is called a lei (pronounced lei). It was the primary soil-turning farming tool in pre-Qin China and the ancestor of the modern plow. Farmers would press the pointed tip into the soil and step on the crossbar to loosen the earth.

Just ahead, we arrive at the Chu Nanqiang Exhibition Hall. Born in Yixing in 1876, Mr. Chu Nanqiang served as county magistrate of Yixing three times and twice in Nantong after the 1911 Revolution, earning a great reputation. Single-handedly spearheading the restoration and development of both Shanjuan Cave and Zhanggong Cave, he is remembered as the pioneer of cave tourism in China and the founder of modern tourism in Yixing. The hall is divided into three sections: A Family of Scholars, Moving Mountains with Determination, and Devotion to Country and Home. Right ahead is the ticket checkpoint. Let's have our tickets ready as we step inside the main cave—Shanjuan Cave!

STOP 04 · 4:22 · WATER DROPS & GUZHENG · shanjuan_04_middle_cave.mp3

The Middle Cave: Lion and Elephant Arena (Shixiang Dachang)

30,000-Year-Old Mainstay Peak, Green Lion & White Elephant, Zisha Guanyin Sea Island & "Yujie Xiandu"

Everyone, welcome inside Shanjuan Cave! Covering roughly 5,000 square meters, the cave is grand and magnificent—like an intricately carved stone palace or a natural museum of abstract art. The entire system spans three levels and four interconnected caverns: the Upper Cave, Middle Cave, Lower Cave, and Water Cave, each brought to life with its own themed light-and-shadow show.

We are now in the Middle Cave. Look up toward the ceiling, where two butterflies seem to flutter side by side through a dreamlike realm. Behind them rises a massive stalagmite pillar called Mainstay Peak (Dizhu Peak), named because it looks like a mighty rock standing firm in the rushing Yellow River. Geologists tell us this seven-meter-tall pillar was formed drop by drop as calcium carbonate in the dripping cave water slowly crystallized over more than 30,000 years! Perched right at the top of the pillar is a natural rock formation resembling Maitreya Buddha—known as the "Welcoming Buddha," smiling toward the entrance to greet visitors from all over the world.

Above us, floating sky lanterns and dancing butterflies make the cavern feel like a celestial palace. You can even scan the QR code with your phone to write a wish and release your own digital sky lantern onto the cave ceiling! Also carved high above are the four characters for "Lion and Elephant Arena" (Shixiang Dachang), inscribed by the noted educator Mr. Lü Fengzi.

Why is it called the Lion and Elephant Arena? Look to both sides of the hall, where two giant natural rock formations stand guard—one shaped like a Green Lion, and the other like a White Elephant. On the White Elephant, you can clearly make out its long trunk touching the ground, along with its tusks, front legs, and hind legs. Across from it, the Lion tilts its head slightly, with a curved waist, raised hindquarters, and a long tail trailing to the floor. There are interactive pads in front of both the Lion and the Elephant—feel free to step onto them to "awaken" these ancient guardians!

An old poem describes this scene: "At the cave entrance stands the Buddha; flanking the lotus throne are the Green Lion and White Elephant." Right beside the White Elephant sits a lifelike statue of Guanyin, the Bodhisattva of Compassion, invited here from Mount Putuo in Zhejiang. Hidden behind her are eight smaller Guanyin statues handcrafted from local Yixing Zisha purple clay. Together, they form the "Guanyin Sea Island," a traditional layout often seen facing the back door of main Buddhist temple halls.

As we walk forward toward the left pool, look up at the rock wall: the light projection recreates memory fragments of the Butterfly Lovers, Liang Shanbo and Zhu Yingtai, leaning together over their books, accompanied by two butterflies dancing in devotion before merging into one. This is a wonderful spot to pause and take photos. Now look straight ahead at the four large seal-script characters carved into the rock wall. Read from right to left, they say "Yujie Xiandu"—a phrase bestowed upon Shanjuan Cave by Tao Hongjing, the famous scholar and Taoist master of the Southern Liang Dynasty. In Buddhist and Taoist thought, Yujie refers to our busy mortal world, while Xiandu means the capital of immortals. Put together, it means "A Fairy Paradise on Earth."

STOP 05 · 3:16 · BAMBOO FLUTE MELODY · shanjuan_05_upper_cave.mp3

The Upper Cave: Cloud and Mist Arena (Yunwu Dachang)

Year-Round 23°C Eternal Spring, Auspicious Stone Bats, 1986 Journey to the West Filming Site & Pangu Pool

Let's head up the stairs on the left toward the Upper Cave. Notice how the huge rock formation above acts like a natural curtain, blocking air convection between the Middle Cave and the Upper Cave. Because of this, the Upper Cave stays at a constant, comfortable temperature of around 23 degrees Celsius (73°F) all year round—warm in winter, cool in summer, like eternal spring! In winter, the temperature difference between the inside and outside fills the entire cavern with swirling white mist, which is why the Upper Cave is called the "Cloud and Mist Arena."

Straight ahead of us is a romantic scene of Butterflies Dancing Among Intertwined Branches. Two ancient trees appear to grow into one, surrounded by blooming flowers and fluttering butterflies—a symbol of freedom and eternal love. You can step onto the interactive platform here to experience this fairytale scene up close.

On our left is a natural rock formation called “Water Town of Jiangnan.” By the pool stands a lush, lifelike stone “willow tree.” Look up above it, and you’ll spot a giant stone bat spreading its wings as if flying toward us, with a smaller bat following right behind. In traditional Chinese culture, the word for bat (fu) sounds identical to the word for good fortune and blessing (fu), so seeing bats here means “blessings arriving from all directions!”

Next to it, clusters of stalactites hang down like shy, budding lotus flowers reflected in the crystal-clear water below—creating a magical illusion of “flowers in the water and the moon in the mirror.” Fun fact: the Upper Cave’s dramatic rock formations were so vivid that Episode 8 of the classic 1986 television series Journey to the West—the Yellow Wind Cave scene where the monk Tang Seng was tied up—was filmed right here!

Look just above our heads at that translucent stalactite with tiny water droplets hanging from its tip. As each drop evaporates ever so slightly, a microscopic ring of calcium carbonate is left behind, allowing the stalactite to grow millimeter by millimeter over thousands of years. Beside it is a natural rock picture known as “Mountain Eagle Teasing a Bear,” and to the right stands a twin stone column that grew together over tens of thousands of years, symbolizing love that never parts. Beside us is Pangu Pool. See that small natural spring opening on the rock wall? Millions of years ago, ancient seawater broke through a tiny fissure right here and slowly dissolved the limestone to hollow out this vast cavern—so the Upper Cave actually began forming from this very spot!

STOP 06 · 2:00 · CLASSICAL GUZHENG · shanjuan_06_baibing_xiaochu.mp3

The “All Illnesses Vanish” Inscription (Bai Bing Xiao Chu)

The Touching Friendship of Industrialist Rong Desheng & Developer Chu Nanqiang, Re-inscribed by Rong Yiren

At the entrance to the stairway leading down, look at the four bold characters carved into the rock wall: “Bai Bing Xiao Chu”—meaning “May All Illnesses Vanish.” These characters were re-inscribed in October 1986 by Mr. Rong Yiren, the former Vice President of China.

There is a touching story behind them. The original calligraphy was actually written by Rong Yiren’s father, Mr. Rong Desheng, the famous patriotic industrialist from Wuxi. Mr. Rong and cave developer Mr. Chu Nanqiang were close friends. When Mr. Rong learned that Chu Nanqiang had exhausted his entire family fortune to restore Shanjuan Cave—even selling off his wife’s jewelry and his daughter-in-law’s dowry—he was deeply moved and generously donated all the cement and steel bars needed to finish the project.

When Shanjuan Cave officially opened on November 11, 1934, Chu Nanqiang invited Mr. Rong to visit. Although Mr. Rong was feeling slightly unwell that day, he came anyway. After exploring the upper and lower caves, he was so captivated by the magical scenery and felt so uplifted that his discomfort completely disappeared! Inspired, he picked up a brush and wrote “Bai Bing Xiao Chu” (“All Illnesses Vanish”). Sadly, the original carving was destroyed during the Cultural Revolution, so his son Rong Yiren re-inscribed it here in 1986. Standing here today, I also wish all of you abundant health, happiness, and joy!

STOP 07 · 2:34 · WATERFALL & CHIME · shanjuan_07_lower_cave_waterfall.mp3

The Lower Cave & The Subterranean Waterfall

The 10-Year Hand-Chiseled 105-Step Tunnel, Nine-Tiered Pools, Buddha's Hand Curtain & Underground Waterfall

Ahead of us is the 105-step staircase, descending five stories deep into the Lower Cave. Originally, the Middle Cave and Lower Cave were not connected at all—visitors had to walk outside and go around the mountain. Starting in 1925, twenty stonemasons worked here every single day to chisel a tunnel through the solid rock. Because explosives would have damaged the delicate cave structure, they couldn't use dynamite. Instead, they used an ingenious "gong-striking sound method"—tapping and listening to the echo through the rock while chiseling upward from the bottom and downward from the top at the same time. Progress was painstakingly slow, and it took a full ten years to carve out this shortcut!

On rainy days, as you spiral down these stairs, every turn echoes with a different natural sound from the rushing water outside—first like roaring wind and thunder, then like surging ocean waves, then like ringing war drums, and finally like ten thousand galloping horses. That is why the four stone archways along the stairs are named Wind and Thunder, Surging Waves, Golden Drums, and Ten Thousand Horses.

Stepping into the Lower Cave, you can see a figure seated in meditation beneath a towering stone pine—that is Master Shanjuan, the discoverer of our cave. Moving forward, on our right are the Nine-Tiered Pools (Jiudie Chi), formed naturally by dripping water and shaped just like terraced rice fields in southern China. In ancient China, the number nine represented the highest number, symbolizing infinity. On our left, sheets of hanging stalactites drape across the cave opening like a curtain of Buddha's hands, earning it the name "Buddha's Hand Curtain."

Beyond this curtain lies the signature spectacle of Shanjuan Cave: the cliffside waterfall plunging straight into the underground cavern! When developer Chu Nanqiang stood here, he wrote a famous poem comparing the waterfall to the Milky Way pouring down from heaven into the belly of the mountain, roaring like underground thunder.

STOP 08 · 2:16 · CRYSTAL RIVER & FINALE · shanjuan_08_water_cave_closing.mp3

The Water Cave (Crystal Palace) Boat Ride & Finale

120-Meter Underground River Boat Ride Through Three Bends, the Water Pass & Passing Through the Dragon Gate

Walking back from the waterfall, we arrive at our final highlight—the Water Cave, also known as the Crystal Palace. Please watch your step as we board the boat!

The Water Cave is an ancient underground river stretching 120 meters long, winding through three gentle bends. Right ahead is the "Water Pass" (Shuiguan), where the rock ceiling dips to its lowest point. As our boat glides forward, dreamy butterfly lights dance across the vaulted ceiling like floating clouds and starry reflections on the water—making you feel as if you are rowing through the Milky Way itself.

Look closely at the walls of the Water Cave, and you'll notice countless smaller grottos, all interconnected. Every single one was carved by underground water dissolving the limestone over millions of years. In fact, a karst cave is never truly finished—it is still changing and evolving every single moment. With its winding river bends, sheer rock cliffs, low overhanging ceiling, and fantastical stone shapes, riding through here feels just like traveling through a tunnel in time.

As the famous Chinese poem goes: “Where hills and streams seem to end and no path remains, beyond shady willows and bright flowers another village appears!” As our boat rounds the third and final bend and passes through the “Dragon Gate” (Longmen), daylight suddenly opens up before us—bringing our dreamlike underground journey to a wonderful close. Ladies and gentlemen, please stay seated until the boat comes to a complete stop, and then step off carefully and follow the path out of the cave in an orderly line. Thank you all for exploring Shanjuan Cave with me today, and I wish you a wonderful rest of your trip in Yixing!